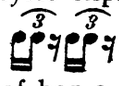
PRELUDE XXIII

A CHECK on the *tempo* of this otherwise obviously vigorous *Allegro* would seem to be given by the beautiful ruminating three-part passage bars 23-28, which certainly must neither be cramped nor suddenly reduced to a markedly slower pace than the rest. But from bar 17 onwards, or perhaps even from bar 12, the piece, which began as if it was going to be a duet in as formal a style as the D♯ minor or the G♯ minor Prelude of this Book, drifts into a fantasia-style more like the opening of a *toccata*. This being so, there is room for plenty of freedom, especially if a sonorous tone be adopted from the outset to account for a broad delivery of the passages that are to become freely declamatory. Bars 15-16 can then be given with special emphasis and breadth (this is necessary in any view, as will be seen at the end), and at bar 17 the hands will join as a single part (except for the deep fundamental bass-notes) in a long cadenza-like run. Be particularly careful to conceal the joins of these scales. Then at bar 23 it will be quite natural that the rhapsody should steady itself to a pace at which the bass figure is not inferior to what it was in the right-hand of bars 3-7, while the upper parts have room, perhaps growing room, for lyric expression. The grace-notes may be a shade shorter than semiquavers, almost triplets,  . Then in bar 28 the free run is resumed, leading to a preparation in terms of bar 3 for the return of the opening. This obviously makes a big climax, and bar 36 may well bear a *ritardando*. Then the opening duly returns, reversing the parts of right and left hand, freely recapitulating bars 7½-10 in the tonic, and abruptly closing therein with bars 15-16. Note the short last chord. Such things are no mere whims of notation with Bach.

FUGUE XXIII

AFTER an Exposition in which the nobly simple Subject is combined with one of the harmonically richest and most original Countersubjects Bach ever wrote, there is one extra entry of the bass before a short Episode leads to a close in the dominant (bar 27). Here the Subject is combined with a new theme (soprano, bar 28) which is treated as a Second Subject, and answered by itself in the bass (bars 31-33), and again in the soprano (in the next bars) before the First Subject re-enters in combination with it. As it consists of a sequentially coiling figure, it often anticipates higher up in the scale the moment at which it should enter as a member of the Double Counterpoint (it is invertible in the twelfth, as shown in bars 36-37); and it can also combine with the First Subject at a different point (see bars 60-62). Its real entries should be distinguished in tone from its anticipations and from merely episodic allusions. The events throughout the rest of the Fugue are the entries of the First Subject, now always bringing the Second Subject in its train on the second crotchet of the second bar; except in two places. The first exception is the above-mentioned entry at bar 60. The second is the next entry, after a very long Episode,

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on returning to the tonic at bar 75, a very big climax at which the Second Subject (which has been filling the previous four bars twice over) disappears just before it is due to enter. The entries being, then, the events, it is the Episodes which throw them into relief and build up the climaxes. Episode 1, arising in bar 22 out of the scale in bar 4, introduces an unobtrusive new quaver figure (a mere oscillation within a semitone), which becomes conspicuous at the end of the Fugue. Episode 2 (bars 38-41) develops a new short scale-figure (both up and down), apropos of the last upward coil of the Second Subject. It is resumed in Episode 3 (bars 45-47). Episode 4 (bars 56-59), over a bass that ruminates on the Second Subject, comes to a formal close in the subdominant, E major, with surprising effect on the next entry of the First Subject, which (in bar 60) starts on the third of that scale, in order to turn out to be in G♯ minor. Episode 5, as we have seen, prepares the way for a great climax. It concerns itself with the Second Subject in the tenor, with a development of its often clipped-away final suspension in the upper parts (virtually new counterpoints, but compare bars 50-52); and the player can best prepare the climax by treating the Episode as quiet and light throughout its unexpected length; so that not until its eleventh and twelfth bars need a *crescendo* prepare for the grand burst of melody and four-part harmony at bar 75. Episode 6 (bars 78-84) carries on the lines of Episodes 2 and 3. Episode 7 (bars 89-92) accompanies the argument of the Second Subject in the bass with noble fresh counterpoint in the alto and tenor, until the final entry of the soprano brings the Fugue to an end with a glorification of Episode 1.

The *tempo* is a moderate four with only one accent, technically a slow two in the bar. Great depth of tone is needed, with corresponding economy. The Exposition of the Second Subject is a welcome opportunity for using the lighter *piano* values; likewise Episode 5.